Nervous System Regulation Tools

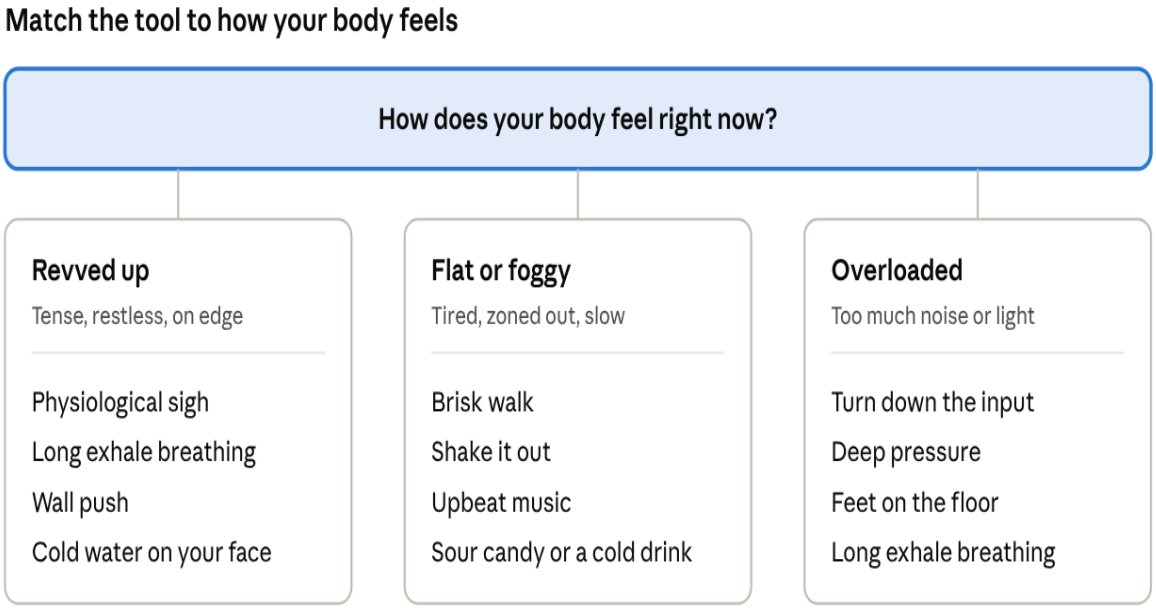
How to use this list

These tools help you calm your body down or wake it up when you need to. Some take 30 seconds. Some are daily habits. You don't need all of them. You need three or four that work for you.

- Try each tool when you're already calm. A tool you've practiced is easier to reach for on a hard day.
- Notice what your body does. A tool might work for you or it might not. Keep what helps and skip the rest.
- Pick tools for different places. Choose one for your desk, one for a break and one for home.
- Go gently. Stop if anything feels uncomfortable.

Find a tool fast

Start with how your body feels right now. Then pick a tool from that group.



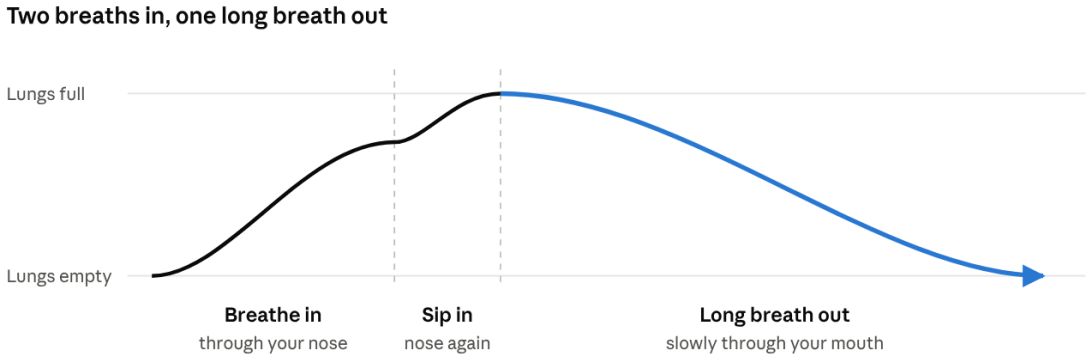
Breathing tools

Your breath is one of the most effective tools you have and it's always with you. Breathe in through your nose when you can. Keep every breath gentle. A long exhale helps your brain to feel more grounded.

Physiological sigh

Two breaths in, one long breath out. You may also hear it called cyclic sighing.

1. Breathe in through your nose until your lungs feel full.
2. Pause then take another short breath of air through your nose.
3. Breathe out slowly through your mouth until your lungs are empty.
4. Repeat 1 to 3 times for a quick reset. Keep going for up to 5 minutes for a deeper calm.

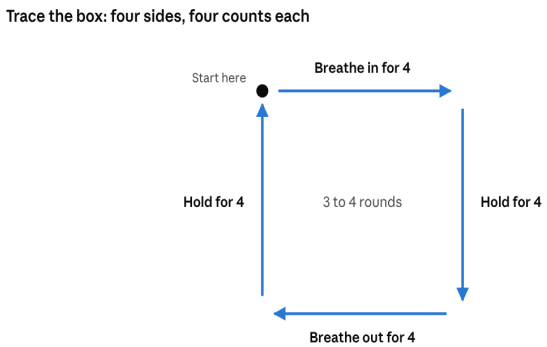


physiological sigh · the shape of one breath

Box breathing

Four equal sides: in, hold, out, hold.

1. Breathe out slowly and empty your lungs.
2. Breathe in through your nose for a count of 4.
3. Hold for a count of 4.
4. Breathe out for a count of 4.
5. Hold for a count of 4.



6. Repeat for 3 to 4 rounds.

If a count of 4 feels too long, count to 3. You're looking for easy, steady breaths.

Long exhale breathing

Make your breath out longer than your breath in.

1. Breathe in through your nose for a count of 4.
2. Breathe out through your nose or pursed lips for a count of 6 to 8.
3. Repeat for 1 to 3 minutes.

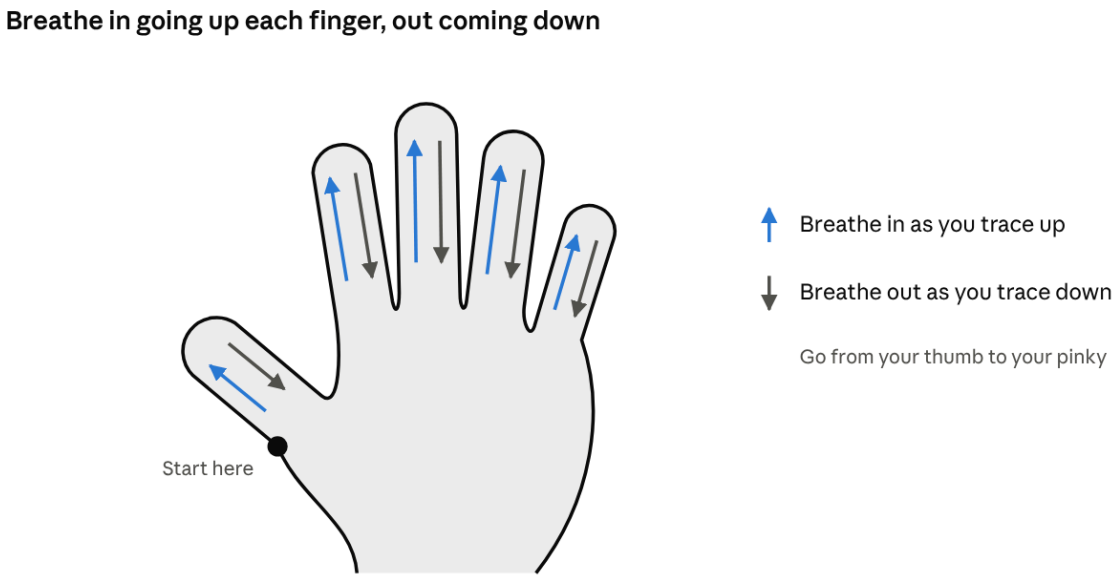
Nobody can see this one. Use it in a meeting, on a call or in line.

Five finger breathing

Trace your hand while you breathe. Touch and breath together give your mind two things to follow.

1. Hold one hand up with your fingers spread.
2. Put the pointer finger of your other hand at the base of your thumb.
3. Breathe in as you trace up your thumb.
4. Breathe out as you trace down the other side.
5. Keep going until you've traced all five fingers. Trace back to your thumb if you want more.

You can do this under your desk or with your hand resting on your leg.



five finger breathing · trace path

Other tools

Cold water on your face

1. Go to a sink and run the water cold.
2. Take a breath in and hold it.
3. Splash the water over your forehead, eyes, nose and cheeks. You can also press a cold wet paper towel over that area.
4. Dry off and take a few slow breaths.

No sink nearby? Hold a cold pack, a cold can or a cold water bottle against your cheeks, the back of your neck, or the sides of your nose depending on your preference.

Cold feels grounding for some people and too intense for others. If it's too much for you, skip this one.

Humming

1. Breathe in through your nose.
2. Close your lips and hum as you breathe out slowly. Pick any note that feels easy or hum your favorite song.
3. Feel the buzz in your lips, throat and chest.
4. Repeat for 5 to 10 breaths.

Body and movement tools

These tools use your muscles, firm pressure and movement. You may find they help most when sitting still feels impossible.

Squeeze and release

You tighten one muscle group, then let it go. You may hear this called progressive muscle relaxation.

1. Sit or lie down somewhere comfortable.
2. Start with your feet. Breathe in and squeeze the muscles for about 5 seconds.
3. Breathe out and let go all at once. Notice the difference for a few moments.
4. Move up your body one area at a time: calves, thighs, belly, back, hands, arms, shoulders and face.
5. The full version takes 10 to 15 minutes.

Squeeze firmly enough to feel it. Stop before it cramps. For a short version at work, do your hands, shoulders and face. That takes about 2 minutes.

Wall push

1. Stand an arm's length from a wall. Put your palms flat on it at shoulder height.
2. Lean in and push like you're trying to move the wall.
3. Hold for a slow count of 10. Keep breathing.

4. Rest, then repeat 3 times.

At your desk, press your palms together in front of your chest. You can also grip the sides of your chair and push down.

Deep pressure

Firm, steady pressure on your body. Pick one way to get it.

- Cross your arms and squeeze your upper arms. Hold for a few slow breaths.
- Press your palms together or squeeze your hands in your lap.
- Rest a weighted lap pad or a heavy bag on your thighs while you work.
- Use a weighted blanket at home for up to 20 minutes.

The pressure should feel firm and comfortable. Make sure you can take off anything weighted by yourself.

Butterfly hug

1. Cross your arms over your chest. Rest each hand just below the opposite collarbone.
2. Tap one hand, then the other, slow and steady.
3. Breathe slowly and keep tapping for 1 to 2 minutes.

At work, tap your left thigh and then your right thigh under your desk.

Shake it out

1. Stand up and shake your hands for 10 seconds.
2. Add your arms and shoulders.
3. Shake one leg, then the other.
4. Stop, stand still and take one slow breath.

Brisk walk

1. Walk a little faster than your normal pace for 5 to 10 minutes.
2. Let your arms swing.
3. Take the stairs or go outside if you can.

To calm down, slow your pace for the last minute and match your breath to your steps.

Stretch

1. Reach both arms overhead and stretch tall as you breathe in.
2. Lower your arms as you breathe out.
3. Roll your shoulders back 5 times.
4. Tip one ear toward your shoulder and hold for 2 breaths. Switch sides.

Sensory and grounding tools

Your senses can pull your attention back to the room you're in. They can also be the reason you feel overloaded. This group covers both.

5-4-3-2-1 grounding

Take one slow breath. Then name these in your head.

1. 5 things you can see
2. 4 things you can touch
3. 3 things you can hear
4. 2 things you can smell
5. 1 thing you can taste

If one sense is hard to find, skip it and move on.



5-4-3-2-1 grounding · 5 senses

Look around the room

1. Let your eyes move slowly around the space. Turn your head too.
2. Look to each side and behind you.
3. Find three things you like the look of. Rest your eyes on each one for a full breath.

Feet on the floor

1. Put both feet flat on the floor.
2. Press down through your heels and toes. Feel the floor push back.
3. Notice the chair holding your weight.
4. Take three slow breaths.

Turn down the input

Less noise, light and activity gives your body room to settle.

- Sound: wear noise reducing headphones, earbuds or earplugs.

- Light: dim your screen, move away from bright overhead lights or wear a hat with a brim if appropriate for your workplace.
- Space: step into a quiet room, a stairwell or your car for 5 minutes.
- People: tell a teammate, "I'm taking five minutes. I'll be right back."

Pick your quiet spot before you need it.

Fidget

- Keep a small quiet object with you. Putty, a smooth stone or a ring you can spin all work.
- Choose a silent one for meetings.

Music

1. Make two playlists. One calms you down and one wakes you up.
2. Pick the playlist that matches where you want your energy to go.
3. Listen for 3 to 5 minutes with headphones.

Strong taste or temperature

A strong sensation can wake you up fast. Pick one.

- Sour candy, mint or gum
- A cold drink or ice
- A crunchy snack

Connection tools

Being near someone safe helps your body settle. That someone can be a person or an animal.

Time with a pet

1. Sit down with your pet where you're both comfortable.
2. Pet them slowly with your whole hand. Use long strokes.
3. Notice their fur, their warmth and their breathing.
4. Stay for about 10 minutes.

No pet at home? Visit a friend's pet or volunteer at a shelter.

A hug

1. Ask someone you trust, "Can I have a hug?"
2. Hold on for three slow breaths. A quick squeeze is over too soon.
3. Let your shoulders drop as you breathe out.

You get to choose the kind of touch that feels good to you. If hugs aren't your thing, sit shoulder to shoulder with someone or ask for a firm squeeze on your shoulders.

Time with a safe person

A safe person is someone you can be yourself around.

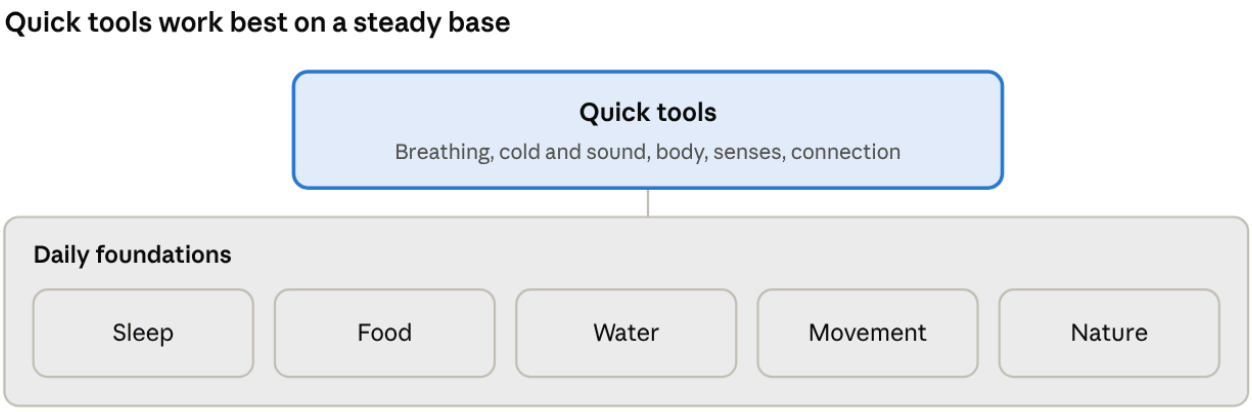
1. Write down two or three safe people.
2. On a hard day, reach out to one of them. Send a text, make a call or sit in the same room.
3. Tell them what you need. You could say, "I don't need advice. I just need company."

Laughing

- Watch a short clip that always makes you laugh.
- Trade memes with a friend.
- Call the person who cracks you up.

Foundations

Quick tools work better when the basics are steady. These five habits set your starting point each day.



foundations · 5 daily habits

Time in nature

1. Find an outdoor spot that feels like nature to you. A park, a tree lined street or a bench near some grass all count.
2. Sit or walk there for 20 to 30 minutes.
3. Try to keep your phone out of sight to help you stay more present.

Short on time? Take 10 minutes. On workdays, eat lunch outside or take a walking break.

Sleep

Aim for 7 or more hours a night.

- Go to bed and get up at the same times every day, weekends too.
- Keep your room quiet, cool and relaxing.
- Put screens away at least 30 minutes before bed.
- Skip caffeine in the afternoon and evening.
- Avoid heavy meals and alcohol close to bedtime.

Food

- Eat at regular times. Try not to skip meals on workdays.
- Add some protein to meals and snacks. Eggs, yogurt, beans and chicken are easy options.
- Keep a snack in your bag or desk.
- You may find you forget to eat when you're focused. Set a phone reminder for lunch.

You've got to eat! Your brain runs on it.

Water

- Fill a water bottle before you leave home. Keep it where you can see it.
- Drink at set times: with each meal, at each break and when you brush your teeth.
- Add fruit, cucumber,mint, or electrolytes if plain water is boring.

You're drinking enough when you rarely feel thirsty and your urine is light yellow.

Daily movement

- Move in a way you enjoy on most days. Walking, dancing, biking, lifting and swimming all count.
- Attach it to something you already do. Walk part of your commute or take the stairs.
- Start small. Ten minutes counts.

Sources: Balban 2023 · Box breathing · Five finger breathing · Diving reflex · Cold water, humming and singing · Humming review · Squeeze and release · 5-4-3-2-1 grounding · Grounding techniques · Pet study · Hug study · Nature study · Sleep · Water

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Build your own Toolkit

Pick one tool for each part of your day and write it in the table. What do you notice as you use the tools?

When	My tool	How will I remember?
Before work		
At my desk		
In a meeting		
On a break		
After work		
Before bed		

- ☐ Pick three tools to try this week.
- ☐ Practice each one once a day while you're calm.
- ☐ Put a reminder where you'll see it, like a sticky note or your lock screen.
- ☐ After a week, keep the tools that helped and swap out the ones that didn't.